

FWS: Philosophy in Practice
Morality and Self-Interest
Fall 2026
Course Syllabus

This course has students reading and writing on philosophical questions concerning morality and self-interest, including: Can morality be based on self-interest? Is it possible to pursue them both without conflict? If self-interest and morality do conflict with each other, which should I follow and why? Does the human psyche allow for truly selfless motives, or is our motivation exclusively self-interested by its very nature? Are there objective facts about what I morally ought to do, are there objective facts about what's in my self-interest to do, is there more objectivity in one than another, or could it turn out that both are a mere illusion? We'll read from classic texts from Plato, Hobbes, Butler, Hume, and others, and discuss contemporary philosophical work as well.

Instructor: Prof. Cole Mitchell

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Office: Goldwin Smith G67

Office hours: Friday 10AM – 11AM and by appointment

Class time: Tuesdays/Thursdays 1:25 to 2:40PM

Classroom: Rockefeller Hall 183

Course website: Canvas

Required work: A total of 100 points is possible:

- (1) Writing Assignment #1 (10 points)
due sometime in Week 3
- (2) Writing Assignment #2 (10 points)
due sometime in Week 7
- (3) Writing Assignment #3 (10 points)
due sometime in Week 11
- (4) Writing Assignment #4 (10 points) / Oral Presentation (40 points)
due sometime in Weeks 15/16
- (5) Attendance (10 points)
- (6) Discussion participation, in-class work (5 points)
- (7) Logic module on Canvas (5 points)

Texts: The readings will also be available online on the course website.

Reference text: The most important of these is the online *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (plato.stanford.edu).

Email policy: I will check email at least twice a week. If I haven't yet responded to your email, you are strongly encouraged to send follow-up emails—I will not be offended!

Main Readings:

Week 1: Plato's *Republic*, Book 1 and the Ring of Gyges

Week 2: Hobbes's *Leviathan*, Chapters 13–15

Week 4: David Gauthier, "Morality and Advantage"

Week 5: Mark Twain, "What Is Man?" (excerpt); Joseph Butler, Sermon 11

Week 6: Feinberg, "Psychological Egoism"

Week 8: Robert Nozick, "The Experience Machine", Julia Annas, *Intelligent Virtue* (excerpt)

Week 9: J. S. Mill, "Utility of Religion" (excerpt)

Week 10: James Edwin Mahon, "Kant, Morality, and Hell"

Week 12: Mary Midgley, "On Trying Out One's New Sword on a Chance Wayfarer"

Week 13: J. L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*, Chapter 1

Week 14: David Hume, the "is-ought" paragraph; Jean Hampton, *The Authority of Reason* (excerpt)

Possible Additional Readings:

- Hume's 2nd *Enquiry*, Chapter 9
- Derek Parfit, "What Makes Someone's Life Go Best?"
- Bernard Williams, "Interlude: Relativism"

NOTE: The information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade and absence policies, may be subject to change with reasonable advance notice, as deemed appropriate by the instructor.